

The Nature of Sacred Scripture

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REL 362: Interpreting Sacred Traditions

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I believe that the Sacred Scriptures originated as faithful testimonies and traditions of God's people, traditions that developed throughout the biblical age. The Holy Spirit guided the development of these traditions by working through the hearts and minds of the people in the communities from which the traditions emerged. The Holy Spirit also worked "in and through" a diverse set of authors to compose the sacred texts (*DV* 11). Because of the divine inspiration of the texts, it is right to call the Sacred Scriptures the "Word of God," meaning that they infallibly convey the truths necessary for salvation and work in living conversation with God's people. We must also recognize that they were written by human authors who recorded only what was revealed to them. As such, they are not intended to be fully inerrant in secular matters, but remain inerrant in all truths of salvation which God intended to convey (*DAS* 3).

To understand the nature of Sacred Scripture, one must understand the nature of divine revelation. Divine revelation is the "initiative taken by God to communicate with humanity," (*JPSS* 23). God chooses to speak to creation through His chosen people. Before Christ, God revealed Himself through the traditions of the Israelites. In this age, however, God has revealed Himself through the tradition of the Church, which is informed by the teachings of Jesus. The author of Hebrews expresses this by saying, "God spoke to our ancestors in many and various ways by the prophets, but in these last days He has spoken to us by [His] Son," (Hebrews 1:1-2).

The quote from Hebrews also mentions that the process of divine revelation is varied, especially in the age before Christ. In some instances, God spoke to His people directly through great wonders or miracles (such as when He manifested Himself to the Israelites by parting the waters of the Red Sea). In other instances, God spoke to His people by directly speaking to them through select spokespersons. These spokespersons, whom we regard as prophets, in some way heard or realized the voice of God and wrote down His instructions. Sometimes, God's communication to the prophets was very direct (such as when He dictated the Decalogue to be written by Moses). Other times, God's communication to the prophets was less direct. Finally, there were also instances where God spoke to His people through their various oral traditions and communal testimonies.

Since God revealed Himself to His people through this wide variety of modes, it is understandable that the formation of the Sacred Scriptures was a long process. Over the course of many centuries, the traditions of the Israelites were written down and assembled into the books of the "Old" Testament.

[A]ncient precepts were assembled in collections which were gradually inserted in the books of the Pentateuch. The older narratives were likewise committed to writing and arranged together. Collections of narrative texts and rules of conduct were combined. Prophetic messages were collected and compiled in books bearing the prophets' names. The sapiential texts, Psalms and didactic narratives were likewise collected much later. (*JPSS* 9).

Tradition also revealed the canon of the "New" Testament, since it was through the "apostolic tradition" of the early Christian Church that the Gospel narratives, epistles, and other texts were passed on and preserved (*JPSS* 10). The sources of the New Testament were the traditions passed on by Christ to His disciples. His disciples were eyewitnesses to His divinity (Luke 1:2). However, the authors of the New Testament "did not know that they were writing Scripture," (Powell 50). The authors were aware that they did not fully record their divine revelations from Christ and, in some cases, admitted that their written testimonies were

incomplete in relaying the traditions that were given to them (John 20:30, 21:25). Still, it is through this direct connection to the divine revelations of Jesus that the early Christian Church traced its apostolic tradition. In its infancy, the Church carefully accepted certain texts into its New Testament canon. Through the guidance of the Holy Spirit, the Church selected texts that it recognized as mainstream and orthodox in their teachings (Powell 51).

Just as the formation of Sacred Scripture was accomplished through divine revelation and guidance, so too is its authorship of divine origin. Divine inspiration is the “extraordinary action of the Holy Spirit in the mind and heart of those involved in the production of the Scriptures.” God, through the process of divine inspiration, guided the testimonies of both early Jewish and Christian communities and governed the transmission of those testimonies throughout the centuries until they were eventually written down as sacred texts (*GS* 15).

God chose to use human authors to write the texts and, “acting in them and through them,” allowed them to communicate His inspired truths in human language (*DV* 11). These human authors freely used common expressions, rhetorical devices, and literary forms to articulate the truths that were revealed to them. These modes of expression, which were familiar to their original ancient near-east audiences, were tools that the human authors used to better impress their messages to the people to whom they were originally written (*DAS* 37). We should also recognize that apparent inconsistencies or lack of details in the biblical narratives would not have been deemed important to their original audiences. “The actual details of historical events were far less important to an ordinary person of ancient times than was the *pattern* by which it was explained and the essential primeval event to which it was compared,” (Boadt 59). With these linguistic dynamics in mind, we should prudently read the Sacred Scriptures, mindful of the human author’s rhetoric, so that we can clearly see the original intent of the divine author (*DAS* 38-39).

Sacred Scripture is part of God’s initiative to communicate with humanity. That is why, being written by humanity, the Sacred Scriptures are written with human expressions in human language. It is a miracle that shows the condescension of God to humankind since He has allowed His eternal wisdom to be revealed to us in our weakness without dilution (*DV* 13). The actual processes of divine inspiration and condescension are mysteries to us (*GS* 15), but since we affirm that divine inspiration implies divine authorship, we can embrace the Sacred Scriptures as being the Word of God (*DV* 24).

[S]o far is it from being possible that any error can co-exist with inspiration, that inspiration not only is essentially incompatible with error, but excludes and rejects it as absolutely and necessarily as it is impossible that God Himself, the supreme Truth, can utter that which is not true. (*PD* 20).

The Sacred Scriptures are regarded as inerrant because of the divine revelation from which they emerged (*DFC* 2), and because of their divine inspiration. Since the Holy Spirit presided over the authorship of Sacred Scripture, the assertions of the human authors are also assertions of the divine author (*DV* 11). To say that they do contain error either rejects the nature of Sacred Scripture as the Word of God or rejects the nature of God as infallible.

However, the inerrancy of the Sacred Scriptures is limited – only that which was divinely revealed to the human authors can be understood as inerrant. God did not intend for divine revelation to teach secular truths which can be learned from general revelation. Rather, through the Sacred Scriptures, He effectively teaches truths that pertain to salvation and spiritual life.

Therefore, Sacred Scripture still retains its inerrancy even when (due to the limited revelation of the human authors) it is errant in matters including history, science, and related subjects (*DAS* 3). In this way, the Holy Spirit inspired the human authors such that they “consigned to writing everything and only those things which He wanted.” As such, the salvific, spiritual, and theological assertions of the Sacred Scriptures are indeed true assertions of the Holy Spirit. It is in this sense that the inspired writings are “useful for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness,” (2 Timothy 3:16).

Even though Sacred Scripture may err in secular matters, it remains trustworthy in sacred matters. Certain literary forms that were employed by the human authors lend themselves to hyperbole, figurative language, symbolism, and other forms of rhetoric in order to communicate specific messages (Evans 11). For example, the flood depicted in the early chapters of Genesis seems to imply that a great flood covered the entire world. However, understanding that the great flood narrative follows the literary conventions of an ancient near-east epic, we are invited to engage in this text as we would engage similar traditional works. We can conclude that, while the narrative “may contain some historical traces, the primary purpose was to provide religious teaching” (*GS* 28). With this, we discover that we can read the theological meanings of the flood narrative separate from its supposed historical meanings. It would not be unreasonable to conclude that the flood could have been regional even though Noah would have perceived the flood as being worldwide. However, this technique does not work in all places. For example, the physical resurrection of Christ is an event recorded in the New Testament that is regarded as essential to understanding the Christian faith. The resurrection is affirmed as a historical reality by numerous authors using different literary forms. In one of his instructory letters to the Christian community of Corinth, Paul brazenly states that “if Christ has not been raised, then our proclamation has been in vain and your faith has been in vain,” (I Corinthians 15:14). Paul teaches that belief in the physical resurrection is non-negotiable for Christians. Unlike the worldwide flood, belief in historical reality of the physical resurrection is intrinsically tied to its theological realities (Evans 178).

Since the Sacred Scriptures emerged out of human communities and were written into human language, a faithful exegesis of any passage of Sacred Scripture first demands that the reader read both the text itself and its surrounding historical context. For this, biblical scholars often utilize the “historical-critical method” of interpretation. The historical-critical method applies many layers of textual and rhetorical analysis to accurately study historical texts (*IBC* 1A). Once the reader has achieved a sound understanding of the literal sense of a passage of text, the reader can reach a more profound understanding of the text by interpreting it in the spiritual sense. This involves prayerfully analyzing a passage’s theological (pertaining to the nature of God), allegorical (pertaining to parallels, types, and similar elements of faith), moral (pertaining to virtuous living), and anagogical (pertaining to eternal reality) dynamics in conversation with the rest of divine revelation (*CCC* 117).

Yet, variance in our interpretations of Sacred Scripture, even to the salvific portions of the sacred texts, still remains. There is ever-present disagreement about the correct interpretation of particular biblical passages, the correct interpretation of their historical backgrounds, and the correct application of these passages in the lives of God’s people. This may come as a challenge to some people who, unable to fathom the existence of blurry lines between correct and incorrect interpretations of the biblical texts, cannot reconcile the resulting interpretive pluralism. However, when we accept that these texts are the Word of God, we must not bind them to a limited set of interpretations. Even among those who come from similar backgrounds, Scripture

yields for different readers “different interpretations and applications of its many teachings,” (Evans 101). By acknowledging that the truths of Sacred Scripture come from an infinite God, we can approach His written Word with a nigh infinite set of interpretations. “No single interpretation can exhaust the meaning of the whole, which is a symphony of many voices,” (*IBC* IIIA). Of course, this approach should be subject to our acceptance of Sacred Scripture’s underlying truthfulness. Any interpretations that we bring to our reading of Sacred Scripture should remain faithful to the essential core of Sacred Scripture, so as to avoid contradicting or misrepresenting the intentions of the divine author.

With this understanding of the interpretation of Sacred Scripture, we must again be prudent in discerning meaning from particular texts. We need to be mindful of the rhetorical techniques in many of the common ancient near-east literary genres. We should also be attentive to underlying cultural factors that may have influenced the writing of the human authors. In doing so, we should also be careful not to undermine the role of the Holy Spirit as the divine author of Sacred Scriptures (*DV* 12).

The Sacred Scriptures contain several narratives that are in apparent tension with one another. Notably, inspired commands for violence seem to present challenges to the rest of Scriptures’ description of God as a compassionate and loving God (eg. Joshua 11:19-20). Certainly, we should not ignore these tensions in Scripture (we should never ignore any parts of Scripture) since they give us a fuller understanding of the character of the sacred texts. When we strip these elements from the text, we “misrepresent the form and focus” of the human authors’ compositions (Kuhn 128) and lose the raw emotions that they poured into their writings. Once again, when addressing these texts (or any other sacred texts), we should attempt to understand the effect that particular historical and cultural contexts would have had on the human authors. Such notions would not be a result of divine revelation, but instead would be the result of the temporal agendas of the human authors (Evans 73), evidence of the human perspectives in and through which the Holy Spirit composed His Word. Additionally, we should consider the sociological, moral, and theological dynamics that exist within and as a result of these passages (*JPSS* 56). This opens a multitude of possible interpretations for these difficult passages that neither ignore the tensions nor reject the inspired nature of Sacred Scripture (*VD* 42).

Having uncovered the human dynamics of the Sacred Scriptures, we can now appreciate the intrinsic, divine beauty of the Word of God. For, underneath the dozens of individual “books” of sacred texts that were gradually compiled over the course of many centuries lies a beautifully crafted, inexhaustible masterpiece of thrilling narratives, heartfelt emotions, and divine truths. These books are so gracefully interwoven and interconnected, such that we should “not isolate particular texts and understandings from the rest of Scripture, but should be attentive to the content and unity of the whole of Scripture,” (*GS* 18). This is especially true when we use the New Testament to illuminate and fulfill the hidden proclamations of the Old Testament (*DV* 16). In fact, it is through these new methods of interpretation that we uncover a “fuller sense” of the Sacred Scriptures (*GS* 20).

This recognition of the Word of God does more than unify the texts of Sacred Scripture – it also unifies God’s people. Since the Word of God transcends limitations, it is no surprise that communities and individuals from every culture can find their own expressions of the Word of God. In this way, the Word of God surpasses time, culture, language, and nation to bind God’s people into communion with one another (*VD* 116). Here, we can recognize that Sacred Scripture is actually in living dialogue with the communities of God’s people (*IBC* IIIA).

The Word of God, in its transcendent, inexhaustible truth, also allows us to enter into dialogue with the divine author (*VD* 24). Because of their divine inspiration, the Sacred Scriptures speak to every person in every time and place, not as a definitive rulebook for every aspect of life, but as instructions for the discernment and fulfillment of God's Will within every person's life (Kuhn 136). Instead of being a rulebook, the Sacred Scriptures present us with "a cacophony of voices and perspectives, all in conversation with one another, representing the breadth and depth of the human experience in all its complexities and contradictions," (Evans 103). The Sacred Scriptures invite us into a dynamic conversation with God and His people – one that allows His people to wrestle with its truths and transform our lives according to His Word (Evans 28).

In summary, the Sacred Scriptures are the product of the development of faithful testimonies of God's people through the gift of divine revelation. These divinely-sourced traditions were later written down by the Holy Spirit working in and through particular, chosen human authors through the process of divine inspiration. The human authors faithfully wrote that which was revealed to them. The resulting texts are the Word of God. As the Word of God, these texts are inerrant in regard to those truths which the divine author intended to communicate. Also, as the Word of God, the Sacred Scriptures transcend human-imposed limitations. Thus, the Sacred Scriptures can be seen as living, dynamic texts that invite God's people into relationship and dialogue in and with their Creator.

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